

A Short History of Papermaking

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Papermaking is traditionally traced to Cai Lun, an official at the Han imperial court, who is credited with standardizing a pulp-based process around 105 CE. The technique spread slowly westward over the following centuries, reaching the Islamic world by the eighth century and Europe by the twelfth.

Materials and process

Early paper was made from a mixture of fibrous materials, including:

- mulberry bark
- hemp waste
- old rags and fishing nets
- bamboo, in later regional variants

The fibers were pulped, suspended in water, and lifted out on a mesh screen. Pressing and drying removed the remaining water, leaving a flexible, foldable sheet – a considerable improvement over papyrus or parchment for everyday writing.

Comparative costs

The table below gives illustrative relative costs of common writing surfaces before and after paper became widely available.

Surface	Relative cost	Durability
Papyrus	Medium	Low
Parchment	High	High
Paper	Low	Medium

A simple diagram

The figure below sketches the basic pulp-to-sheet process.

Later developments

Mechanized paper production in the nineteenth century, driven by the Fourdrinier machine, shifted the raw material from rags to wood pulp and made paper cheap enough for mass printing. This is the point at which paper stopped being a craft good and became an industrial commodity.

Papermaking process

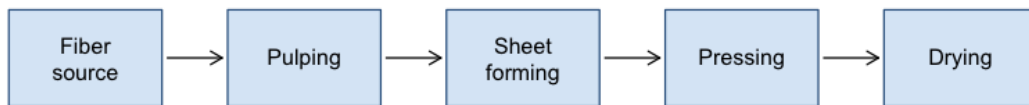


Figure 1: Papermaking process, from pulp to dried sheet